

THE GENTLEMAN RULES

10 notes for a new era.

— *R.*

BEFORE WE START

A note from the atelier.

I learned most of what I know in a small atelier on the Lower East Side. Sal, my mentor, ran it for forty years. He taught me how to cut a suit — and, without ever announcing it, how to be a man worth wearing one.

None of these notes are new. That's the point. They're the old way: small habits that cost nothing and say everything about you.

The world got faster. Good manners didn't go out of style. They just got rare. And rare is what people remember.

Take one note a week. Wear it until it fits.

— Rory

01

Be early.

WHY IT MATTERS

Being on time tells people their time matters to you. Being late tells them the opposite – no matter how good your excuse is.

HOW TO DO IT

Plan to arrive ten minutes early. Use those minutes to breathe, check your collar and settle in – not to scroll.

THE DETAIL MOST MEN MISS

Early isn't about the clock. It's about arriving calm instead of arriving apologizing. Your first impression starts before you say hello.

"Ten minutes early is on time. On time is already late."

– Sal

02

Phone face down.

WHY IT MATTERS

Undivided attention has become rare. That's exactly why it's so attractive.

HOW TO DO IT

Leave the phone in your pocket. If you really have to check it, excuse yourself and step away for a moment.

THE DETAIL MOST MEN MISS

Even face down, a phone on the table says: something might be more important than you. The real move is the pocket.

"The most expensive thing you can give someone is your full attention."

– Sal

03

Remember the small thing.

WHY IT MATTERS

Anyone can remember a birthday. Remembering the café she mentioned once proves you were actually listening.

HOW TO DO IT

After a conversation, write one detail in your phone. Bring it back weeks later, casually.

THE DETAIL MOST MEN MISS

People rarely remember what you gave them. They remember that you listened. Details are proof.

"Listen twice as much as you talk. You have the ears for it."

– Sal

04

Walk on the street side.

WHY IT MATTERS

It's an old gesture of protection. Almost nobody does it anymore – which is why it still gets noticed.

HOW TO DO IT

Switch sides naturally when you cross the street. No announcement, no speech. Just do it.

THE DETAIL MOST MEN MISS

It's not really about traffic anymore. It's a quiet signal that you're paying attention to her, not to yourself.

"Manners are invisible when they're done right."

– Sal

05

Apologize without "but".

WHY IT MATTERS

"But" erases everything you said before it. A real apology has no fine print.

HOW TO DO IT

Say it in three parts: I was wrong. I'm sorry. Here's what I'll do. Then stop talking.

THE DETAIL MOST MEN MISS

Then do the thing you promised. An apology without changed behavior is just a nicer way of saying it again.

"An apology with an excuse is just an excuse."

– Sal


Manners are the only suit
you never take off.

06

Two sprays. Not six.

WHY IT MATTERS

Your scent should be discovered, not announced. If she smells you before she sees you, it's too much.

HOW TO DO IT

One spray on the neck, one on the wrist. Never re-apply before dinner.

THE DETAIL MOST MEN MISS

Scent works at close range. If it reaches across the table, it's no longer an invitation, it's an interruption. Spray on skin, not on clothes.

"A gentleman is noticed when she leans in. Not before."

– Sal

07

Shoes first.

WHY IT MATTERS

People look down before they look up. Tired shoes ruin a perfect suit.

HOW TO DO IT

Polish them once a week. Match your belt to your shoes. Replace the laces before they fray.

THE DETAIL MOST MEN MISS

Clean shoes say you think ahead. Worn-out heels say you hope nobody looks down. Someone always does.

"You can tell everything about a man by the state of his shoes."

– Sal

08

Tip like you've worked a shift.

WHY IT MATTERS

Character shows with people who can do nothing for you.

HOW TO DO IT

Tip generously, look them in the eye and say thank you – with their name, if you know it.

THE DETAIL MOST MEN MISS

Watch how a man treats the waiter and you know how he'll treat you when the charm wears off. People notice that moment.

"Respect doesn't only go upward. It goes in every direction."

– Sal

09

Be the calm one.

WHY IT MATTERS

In every room there's one person everyone orients to when things get loud. Be that person.

HOW TO DO IT

When others get louder, speak softer. Breathe first, then answer. Calm is a skill – train it.

THE DETAIL MOST MEN MISS

Calm isn't the absence of feeling. It's choosing your response instead of letting the reaction choose you. Breathe out longer than you breathe in.

"Loud men are rarely strong. Strong men are rarely loud."

– Sal

10

Ask if she got home safe.

WHY IT MATTERS

The date doesn't end when the cab door closes. Care doesn't stop at the curb.

HOW TO DO IT

Text her: “Let me know you got home safe.” Then wait. It's not control. It's care.

THE DETAIL MOST MEN MISS

Then keep it light. No interrogation, no follow-up questions. One message, one answer, goodnight.

“Care is a small thing, done every time.”

– Sal

BONUS NOTE

11

The one Sal never wrote down.

Be kind when no one is watching.

WHY IT MATTERS

Every note in here can be performed. This one can't. It's what you do when nobody will ever find out.

HOW TO DO IT

This week, do one kind thing that no one will ever hear about. Not even her. Especially not her.

"That's the whole secret, kid. The rest is tailoring."

— SAL

“

Wealth whispers.
Manners speak.

— RORY VALE

That's ten. Plus one.

There are many more. I share a new note every week – with the why, the how, and sometimes a story from the atelier.

FOLLOW THE NOTES

@roryvale.nyc

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— R.

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